

Abstract

Background

In our everyday lives we come across situations that make us feel things like fear, happiness, disgust, and sadness. These emotions aren't just felt but they have a reason and elicit complicated social emotions such as guilt, shame, pride, humiliation, regret and jealousy (Scheff, 1988). Social emotions play a significant role by prompting us to assess our progress towards life goals and values (Seo et al., 2004). These emotions act as a sort of guide, encouraging us to measure our behavior against societal expectations that are visible to others. So, it's an ongoing process of reflection and evaluation of our interactions with the people. At the heart of this process is our cognitive evaluation or assessment, known as *appraisal*, plays a central role in determining how we react and behave in different situations.

Because, appraisals are the procedures that anticipate individuals' emotional reactions to events based on their cognitions. It contends that events do not cause emotions on their own; rather, individual's appraisal about situations predicts their emotional reactions to situations. Therefore, social emotion guilt, shame, and remorse are interconnected with appraisal as they arise from individuals evaluating their own actions against internalized moral standards. The guilt emotion typically stems from a realization of having violated personal values and prompting a negative appraisal of one's behavior. Similarly, shame is often tied to a broader sense of self-esteem and involving a negative assessment of one's entire self. The remorse reflects an appraisal focused on the specific consequences of one's actions and leading to a desire for behavioral correction. In this way, appraisal redirects people's behavior by determining whether they are likely to experience affirmative or destructive emotions in response to situation.

Previous studies highlighted that social emotions motivate individuals to work hard and behave in moral and socially appropriate ways (Fisher & Tangney, 1995). However, lack of knowledge and mismanagement of these social emotions in day to day life threaten the person's well-being and put the individual into the different physiological (fast heart beat, sleep issues, restless, muscles trembling, feeling cold & warm, speech tempo changes etc.) and behavioral problems. Also, the high reflections of appraisal about the negative occasions lead to adverse self-conscious emotions that push individual into depression, stress, anxiety, aggression, conflict,

frustration and violence, as highlighted by the research of Brown (2007) and Tracy et al., (2013).

Rational of the Study

After reviewing the existing literature, it becomes evident that social emotions have received relatively little attention in scholarly discourse. Contemporary theorists sporadically recognize situational influences on social emotions however limited empirical research has been seen undertaken in the realm of these emotions. It might be due to the substantial cultural and linguistic diversity particularly in sub-continental regions has contributed and diminishing focuses on guilt, shame and remorse emotions. Also, the considerable haze and misinformation and awareness of social emotions become another fact and finally the inadequate descriptions of tools for understanding these social emotions continue to impede progress in the field. These explanations are further expanded and clarified, as outlined below.

Base on Empirical research of social emotions particularly within the subcontinent region, remains notably sparse. Over the past two decades, only a handful of studies have been documented and accessible through platforms such as Google Scholar, PubMed, and Research Gate. Apart from that, previous research has predominantly adopted a *comparative approach* contrasting social emotions between continental vs. sub-continental groups. However, there is still a vast terrain left unexplored within the realm of social emotions in this subcontinent region and demanding further investigation and analysis.

Based on clinical observations, it's clear that shame, regret, guilt, and disappointment are integral to understanding various psychological challenges such as depression (Hamilton, 1982), chronic OCD issues (Lange & Jakubowski, 1976), and eating disorders (Fairburn, 1984). Consequently, this study aims to explore the physiological and psychological differences that arise during experiences of shame, guilt, and remorse, aiming to provide valuable insights corroborating clinical findings and observations.

From a descriptive perspective, there is a critical need to comprehensively assess a wide spectrum of social emotions. The current self-report measures, such as the Forced-Choice Guilt Inventory (FCGI) (Mosher, 1966; 1968; Martin, 2012), have limitations as they narrowly focus on moral domains like morality-conscience, hostility, and sexuality. Similarly, the Perceived Guilt Index (PGI) (Otterbacher &

Munz, 1973; Taušová, 2019) lacks situational references altogether. Hence, this study highlights the significance of scrutinizing the credibility and dependability of current assessment tools utilized in research endeavors. The study fill the existing gap in understanding social emotions, with a specific emphasis on the emotional encounters of guilt, shame, and remorse, particularly in relation to appraisal levels (Wallbott & Scherer, 1988).

Based on the existing observations, it seems that social emotions appear to be in at infancy stage. So, it's an exceptionally prevailing opportunity for investigating and explored social emotions particularly guilt, shame and remorse by the appraisal levels. Because, these emotions are having powerful relevance on individual's life.

Aim 1

Explore the situations that generate the social emotions of guilt, shame and remorse.

Aim 2

Evaluate the emotional experiences of guilt, shame and remorse with the levels of appraisal.

Aim 1: Research Questions

1. What are the situations that generate the social emotions of guilt, shame and remorse?
2. What are the common situations altogether that generate the social emotions of guilt, shame and remorse?

Aim 2: Research Objectives

1. To explore the distribution of guilt in subjective feelings of state by the levels of appraisal.
2. To study the guilt emotion experiences with the levels of appraisal.
3. To explore the distribution of shame in subjective feelings of state by the levels of appraisal.
4. To study the shame emotion experiences with the levels of appraisal.
5. To explore the distribution of remorse in subjective feelings of state by the levels of appraisal.
6. To study the remorse emotion experiences with the levels of appraisal.
7. To see the difference in guilt, shame and remorse experiences between the participants of Jammu and Kashmir and Uttar Pradesh.
8. To see the difference in guilt, shame and remorse experiences between the male and female participants of Jammu & Kashmir and Uttar Pradesh.

Hypothesis

- H₁ : There will be independence in cell frequencies for guilt subjective feelings of state by levels of appraisal.
- H₂ : There will be difference among guilt emotion experiences with the levels of appraisal.
- H₃ : There will be independence in cell frequencies for shame subjective feelings of state by levels of appraisal.
- H₄ : There will be difference among shame emotion experiences with the levels of appraisal.
- H₅ : There will be independence in cell frequencies for remorse subjective feelings of state by levels of appraisal.
- H₆ : There will be difference among remorse emotion experiences with the levels of appraisal.
- H₇ : There will be the difference in guilt, shame and remorse experiences between the participants of Jammu & Kashmir and Uttar Pradesh.
- H₈ : There will be the difference in guilt, shame and remorse experiences between the male and female participants of Jammu & Kashmir and Uttar Pradesh.

Description of Research Design

The parallel mixed method research design was used in the present study. A parallel mixed method design is single phase research approach that involves collecting both quantitative and qualitative data, analyzing them separately, and then combining the findings to provide a more comprehensive understanding of the research problem.

Conclusion

Aim 1

For aim 1, the findings explored 59 situations classified to evoke the social emotions of guilt, shame, and remorse. Among the identified situations, 21 were linked to feelings of guilt, 21 to shame, and 17 to remorse. Interestingly, 15 situations overlapped in evoking both guilt and shame, while 14 were associated with guilt and remorse, and 10 with shame and remorse. The study also identified 9 specific situations (such as performance, sin, cheat, lie, separate, failure, steal, disobey, and damage) capable of eliciting all three social emotions altogether.

Therefore, determine the 59 situations of guilt, shame and remorse separately and altogether. Our findings are aligning with previous researches that similar situations can evoke guilt, shame and remorse separately and altogether. Because, the concurrent experience of guilt, shame and remorse suggests that emotions are not isolated entities but rather interlinked and shape the human behavior and experiences. Also, the factors such as personal values, cultural background, and situational context can contribute to the emotional responses observed in individuals.

Research exploring the simultaneous activation of these emotions can provide valuable insights into the intricacies of human psychology and contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of how individuals navigate and process complex emotional experiences. This understanding, in turn, can have implications for fields such as psychology, sociology, and even ethics, shedding light on the multifaceted nature of emotional responses to moral dilemmas or ethical decision-making. Thus, it infers that social emotional responses are complex multifaceted in nature and influenced by numerous factors.

Aim 2

Guilt, Shame and Remorse Subjective Feelings State

The findings show independence in adult guilt, shame and remorse subjective feelings of state by levels of appraisal. The results are supported by the previous studies that appraisal had a significant independence upon emotions in wide variety of situations. Thus, the experience of guilt, shame and remorse in adults is a multifaceted psychological phenomenon influenced by various cognitive and social aspects. Hence, it infers that individual assessment of situations is based on their personal beliefs, values, and internalized moral standards.

Guilt Emotion Experiences

The results of guilt emotion experiences shed the light on findings that the high level of appraisal shows high guilt emotion experience (bodily symptoms, expressive reactions, verbal reactions and psychological consequences) as compared to moderate and low appraisal levels. Because the high guilt appraisal of the situation amplify the cortisol level leads high stress level and the individual shows more noticeable signs of distress, anxious, restlessness and withdrawing from social interaction. Further, the previous research support the findings that shame, guilt, and

anger elicits different psychological, physiological, and behavioural patterns and these reactive systems influence the social adjustment of young *adults*. Because the guilt appraisal triggers bodily tension, frowns, closed-off gestures, distress verbal expressions, heightened anxiety, reduced self-esteem, and a sense of overwhelm occurs.

Shame Emotion Experiences

The results of shame emotion experiences shed the light on findings that the high level of appraisal shows high level of shame emotional experience of bodily symptoms, expressive reactions, verbal reactions and psychological consequences as compared to moderate and low appraisal levels. Because, the physiological changes associated with low levels of shame appraisal include a slight increase in heart rate, skin conductance and a mild signs of *stress reactions*. Further, the study support the findings that the low levels of shame appraisal of individual display subtle non-verbal cues such as low gazing, slumped posture, discomfort with the situation. Also, the behavioral changes lead withdrawal, desire to hide and seeking to avoid further exposure. *However*, as the level of shame appraisal intensifies, physiological responses become more pronounced, with heightened activation of the sympathetic nervous system leading to increased heart rate, sweating, and blushing. Because the physiological responses potentially leading to a state of extreme distress and individual with shame show the symptoms of minor panic attack, rapid breathing, trembling and a sense of dissociation occurs as researches *shown*. Therefore, the shame operates as a moral emotion and individuals physiological and behaviours changes are occur when shameful event happens.

Remorse Emotion Experiences

The findings of remorse emotion experiences shows the high level of appraisal leads high bodily symptoms, expressive reactions, verbal reactions and psychological consequences as compared to moderate and low appraisal levels. Because, remorse is complex emotion experience characterized by feelings of guilt and regret and having a desire for redemption of wrongdoing. Also, the remorse is associated with increased activation of brain regions such as the anterior insula, amygdala and prefrontal cortex as highlighted by previous studies. These regions are involved in regulating emotions and decision-making and demonstrating the physiological changes that occur during the experience of remorse. Further, the

studies on the autonomic nervous system responses related to guilt and remorse have shown that individuals experiencing more increase in heart rate, perspiration and stress level. Similarly the psychological aspect of the remorse involves a profound sense of moral self-assessment and cognitive reflection. Because the experience of remorse involves a cognitive appraisal of one's actions and leads to self-reproach and internal evaluation of moral standards. Moreover, remorse often involves feelings of empathy and a desire to repair the harm caused and the person motivates for seeking forgiveness and making amends. Thus, it infers that as the level of remorse intensifies, individuals may display changes in expressive behaviour, such as increased displays of sadness, regret and attempts to communicate their feelings of remorse through non-verbal cues.

Residential Comparison

The findings show that the Jammu and Kashmir adults show higher scores on guilt emotion experiences as compared to the Uttar-Pradesh. Because the people of Kashmir residing in the region of South Asia have a rich cultural heritage that greatly values group harmony and social cohesion. They strongly focus on collective culture, mutual respect, and collective well-being. Further, there is a strong sense of community support and mutual assistance among Kashmiri people and they follow the concepts like “Milchar” and “Baradari” so that to maintain togetherness that leads individuals to assist each other during times of need, whether it's in the form of financial help, emotional support, and societal celebrations. Therefore, any disturbances of these aspects lead to guilt among Kashmiri people.

In opposition, shifting of collective culture to individualistic culture experiences the low emotions of guilt. Because the transformation of Uttar Pradesh's collective culture into individual culture is a multifaceted process influenced by several interconnected factors. Urbanization and stitching of communities due to migration contribute to a shift towards more individualistic lifestyles, characterized by a focus on personal goals and aspirations challenging to follow traditional norms and values experiences the person guilt. It's important to recognize that this transition is not uniform and varies across communities and regions within Uttar Pradesh, with elements of collective culture often coexisting with emerging individualistic tendencies.

Gender Comparison

The findings show male adults show higher scores on shame emotion experiences as compared to the female adults. The findings support the previous researches that male experiences more shame than females particularly in contexts related to task failure and bad performance. Because of *traditional masculine schema* that they are physically strong therefore failing any public performance leads to experiences more shame than females. Whereas females experiences shame related to physical (body) patterns and failure in relationships. Because their cognition are tends to revolve around *relational failures* whereas male's shame is more related to *instrumental failures* as highlighted by previous researches.

Similarly, the findings show the female adults show higher scores on remorse emotional experiences as compared to the male adults. Because of the *societal pressures and gender socialization (social expectations)* contributes to the amplified experience of remorse among women. Therefore, women are more socializing than man and given more importance to relationships and harmony, which could intensify their remorse responses to situations where they feel they've caused harm and disrupted social bonds. In this way, females are habitually adopting cultural norms, customs, empathy, nurturing, and emotional sensitivity that leads to heightened feelings of remorse.

Implication

By studying shame, guilt, and remorse emotions can lead to various implication:

Balanced Emotional Life

The identified situations of shame, guilt, and remorse have substantial implication for personal growth and emotional well-being. Because, recognizing these emotions related to specific situations allows individuals to address underlying problems, learn from mistakes, and make positive changes. Further, it will promote self-awareness and accountability to improve decision making and interpersonal relationships. *Also*, individuals can actively work towards emotional resilience, fostering a healthier and balanced emotional life.

Personal and Social Development

Personal and social development through social emotions involves enlightening emotional intelligence, empathy, and communication skills. These aspects foster positive relationships, conflict resolution, and cultural competence. By understanding and managing of guilt, shame and remorse emotions, individuals can build a foundation for meaningful connections, contributing to their overall well-being and creating a healthier social environment.

Therapeutic Interventions

Therapists and counselors can utilize to address emotions of shame, guilt, and remorse to support individuals in their healing process, emotional management, and personal development. By incorporating these targeted approaches, mental health professionals can also guide individuals towards understanding, processing, and overcoming these challenging emotions and ultimately facilitating a journey towards improved well-being and personal growth.

Educational Strategies

Understanding these social emotions can guide the development of educational strategies aimed at to encourage emotional intelligence, empathy, and responsible behavior among students. Such insights offer valuable tools for educators to create environments that not only enhance academic learning but also contribute to the social and emotional development of students and preparing them for well-rounded and responsible citizen.

Cultural Variations

The exploration of cultural distinctions in assessing these social emotions not only unveils variations in norms, values, and societal expectations but also offers insights into diverse cultural frameworks. This understanding sheds light on how these emotions are perceived and expressed across different societies. By delving into these cultural intricacies, the study contributes to enhanced cultural understanding and sensitivity, fostering a broader awareness of the diverse ways in which individuals from various backgrounds experience and navigates these social emotions.

Psychological Well-being

Recognizing and addressing emotions of guilt, shame, and remorse can enhance mental well-being by diminishing harmful patterns like self-blame and promoting self-compassion and acceptance.

Limitation

Sample Comprising

This study limited to a sample comprising only highly qualified students and hence excluding the participants with low level education (below post-graduate) and illiterate participants. As a result, the study's potential for widespread applicability is limited.

Age Range

The study restricted to early adults the age group ranges from 18-30 years poses a limitation in terms of generalizability. Findings and conclusions derived from this specific age cohort might not accurately represent or be applicable to other age groups.

Population Restricts

The study exclusively focused on populations from only two states restricts the scope, potentially limiting the broader understanding of regional variations and reducing the generalizability of findings across a more diverse geographical landscape.

Future Directions

Certainly, understanding the complex emotions of shame, guilt, and remorse opens up numerous pathways for research and application across various domains.

Social Impact

More need to study the societal implication of shame, guilt, and remorse, including how these emotions affect group dynamics behaviour. This could lead to strategies for promoting empathy, forgiveness, and conflict resolution.

Psychometric Measurements and Interventions

Developing effective psychometric measures and interventions that could help individuals to cope and manage these social emotions in healthy ways. This might involve the contribution of different therapeutic approaches, such as dialectical behaviour therapy (DBT), acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), cognitive-behavioural therapy (CBT) and mindfulness-based interventions.

Neuro-scientific Research

Explore the neurological basis of these emotions to better understand their neural pathways, micro facial expressions and brain regions involved. This could lead to insights into treatments and interventions targeting these specific neural mechanisms.

Cultural and Ethical Perspectives

Investigating how different cultures and ethical frameworks view these emotions and their impact on individuals within these contexts. This research could help in developing culturally sensitive approaches to address these emotions.

Legal and Criminal Justice Systems

Assessing how these emotions impact behaviour, rehabilitation, and re-offense rates within the criminal justice system. This could inform healing justice practices and alternative approaches to rehabilitation.

Self-compassion and Resilience

Promoting self-compassion practices and resilience-building techniques can empower individuals to navigate these emotions in a manner that fosters personal growth and psychological well-being and reducing the detrimental effects of shame, guilt, and remorse on mental wellbeing.